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EXECUTIVE PREVIEW

Turning AI Potential into Enterprise Value

Design for Coherence

A short book for the executive team

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BEFORE YOU BEGIN

Ten minutes, one argument

This preview condenses *Turning AI Potential into Enterprise Value* by Erlend Hollebosch into one argument and one method. It is written for executives who sponsored an AI pilot that worked and are still waiting for it to reach the P&L.

> **AI does not create or destroy value on its own; it amplifies the enterprise it enters.**
>
> THE CENTRAL CLAIM OF THE BOOK

The sequence that follows is not a preference but arithmetic: design for coherence first, then amplify. Read it in order, or follow the route for your seat at the table.

Your route through the preview

CEO
The paradox, the argument and the five gates
Pages 4–6 · 15

CFO
What incoherence costs and how value is verified
Pages 9–10 · 18

COO
Workflow redesign and the performance dip
Pages 11–12 · 17

CIO
Backbone, autonomy and the diagnostic
Pages 13–14 · 16

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Ten chapters

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The pilot that worked

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The argument and the numbers

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Nine voices, one root cause

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Amplifier, actor, autonomy

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Value, rules and failure signals

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The first fifteen working days

CHAPTER 01 · INTRODUCTION

01

The pilot worked. That is precisely the problem.

Somewhere in your organisation an AI pilot worked. Processing time fell, quality rose, the board was pleased. Six months later it is still a pilot: the gain is invisible in the P&L, the licence costs are not.

Ask the executive table why, and you hear nine sincere answers. The CFO sees licences before evidence, the COO an operation that cannot pause, the CIO shadow AI and agents without owners, HR a fear no communication plan reaches. Procurement watches lock-in signed before value, Supply Chain a forecast nobody trusts, and business units lose their best people while the benefits are claimed centrally.

Each explanation is locally true — so each fix is only partly effective. Finance tightens funding and pilots slow; IT tightens governance and shadow AI goes underground.

> **The pilot is not failing. The organisation around it is not built to absorb it.**
>
> CHAPTER 1

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- ✔ A successful pilot does not prove the enterprise is ready to scale.
- ✔ Nine locally true explanations point to one shared cause.
- ✔ Fixing symptoms one corner at a time leaves the condition untouched.

CHAPTER 02 · EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

02

The argument in five moves

1 **The pilot is not the problem**
Successful pilots stall because the organisation around them cannot absorb them.

2 **Incoherence is the root cause**
Decisions wait, work keeps changing hands, priorities compete for the same people.

3 **AI amplifies what it finds**
Coherent enterprises compound value; fragmented ones compound confusion.

4 **Coherence can be designed**
Five properties, a fifteen-day diagnostic and five gates with named owners.

5 **Value is verified, not claimed**
Three horizons, five measurement rules and a 1.5× funding threshold.

> “Design for coherence first. Then amplify.
>
> THE SEQUENCE THE BOOK ARGUES FOR

The numbers that matter

3–8%
of revenue lost to incoherence — before anyone mentions AI
CHAPTER 3 · AUTHOR'S EXPERIENCE

30–40%
shorter cycle times in redesigned workflows
CHAPTER 9 · HORIZON TWO

1.5×
verified annual value before any structural funding
CHAPTER 9 · FUNDING RULE

15
working days from mandate to a board decision
CHAPTER 12 · FIRST CALENDAR

6–12
weeks average delay on major cross-functional decisions

15–30%
of a workflow's cost spent on rework and re-entry

150–200%
allocation of the scarce people every initiative needs

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- ✔ The enterprise already pays for incoherence; the question is whether it keeps paying.
- ✔ Every figure here is measured against a baseline, by Finance.
- ✔ The first decision takes fifteen working days, not a programme.

03

Nine voices around one table

Ask why the pilot never scaled and every executive gives a sincere, accurate answer — from where they sit.

CEO
Nine sensible people moving toward an outcome that serves no one

CFO
Licences signed before value is proven

COO
An operation that cannot pause for a transformation

CIO
Shadow AI and agents without owners

HR
A fear of replacement no communication plan reaches

SALES & MARKETING
Promises a fragmented organisation cannot keep

PROCUREMENT
Lock-in signed before value

SUPPLY CHAIN
Buffers removed from a forecast nobody trusts

BUSINESS UNITS
Best people absorbed, benefits claimed centrally

Each explanation is locally true — so each fix is only partly effective. Finance tightens funding and pilots slow; IT tightens governance and shadow AI goes underground. HR launches engagement and the fear stays, because fear was never the root.

The root cause: incoherence

The root cause is not AI, data, culture or leadership. It is **incoherence**: the parts of the enterprise each work reasonably well, but the connections between them — decisions, handovers, priorities, information — no longer form a working whole.

Decisions keep waiting

Many people are involved; no one owns the trade-off.

Work keeps changing hands

Every department does its part; the shared outcome stays out of reach.

Priorities keep competing

Everything is priority one, so nothing is.

None of this was created by AI. It accumulated over decades of local fixes — governance added after incidents, systems bought per department, reorganisations that moved boxes but not decision rights. Each layer solved a local problem; together they built an enterprise too complex to change quickly.

EXECUTIVE INSIGHT · THE TEN-MINUTE TEST

Which decision has been open longer than a month, and who owns it? Which outcome passes through so many hands that no one owns it? How often do the same five names appear across your initiatives? **Two uncomfortable answers mean the pilot was never your bottleneck. The system was.**

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- ✔ Incoherence lives between the parts, not inside them.
- ✔ Three signals reveal it: waiting decisions, travelling work, competing priorities.
- ✔ It predates AI by decades; AI only makes it visible.

04

Coherence is a condition you can check

Coherence is not a slogan but an operating condition. It rests on five properties — none exotic, rare only in combination.

FRAMEWORK · THE FIVE PROPERTIES

1 **Explicit decision rights**
One name owns each decision — in one second.
Missing → decisions keep waiting

2 **End-to-end ownership**
Every outcome that matters has one owner for the whole.
Missing → work keeps changing hands

3 **One priority list**
One ranked portfolio, owned by the executive team as a team.
Missing → priorities keep competing

4 **Information shared by default**
The data a decision needs reaches it without negotiation.
Missing → work waits for data

5 **Designed boundaries**
Every person and every agent knows its authority and its never-do rules.
Missing → all three, amplified by agents

The price of incoherence

Its absence is already on your bill. The author puts it at **three to eight percent of revenue — before AI**. Finance can price it in ten working days, from minutes, calendars and one workflow walk.

DECISION LATENCY

6–12 wk

average delay on major cross-functional decisions

INTERFACE FRICTION

15–30%

of a workflow's cost spent on rework and re-entry

INITIATIVE CONGESTION

150–200%

allocation of key people

This one-page **incoherence statement** is also your AI baseline: whatever AI promises, these three costs discount it. The question is never whether you can afford coherence — you are already paying for its absence.

Two confusions mislead programmes. Coherence is not *alignment*, the offsite where everyone nods; it is what remains three weeks later. Nor is it *standardisation*: the mature position is to standardise the backbone and differentiate the edge. McKinsey's **7S lens** makes the gaps discussable — and agentic AI stresses all seven elements at once.

FOR THE CFO

Commission the incoherence statement: three audits, one page, one number per line, within ten working days. **It becomes the baseline every later funding gate is measured against.**

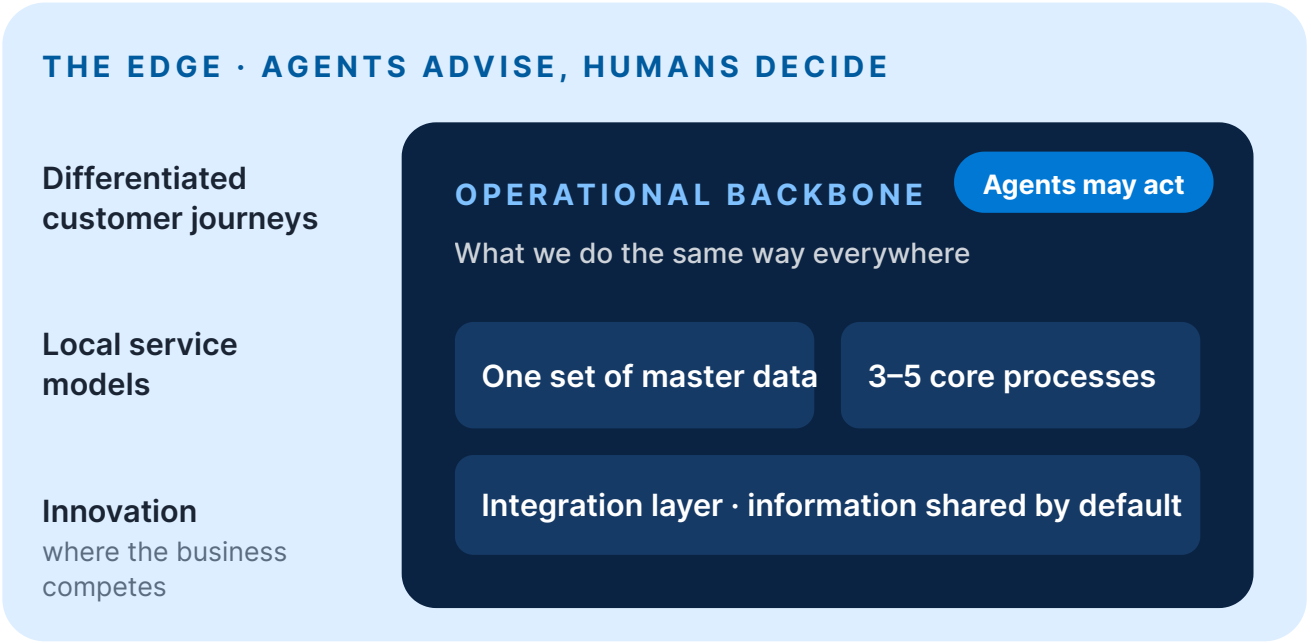
KEY TAKEAWAYS

- ✓ Five properties make coherence checkable in any meeting.
- ✓ Incoherence costs an estimated 3–8% of revenue before AI.
- ✓ Coherence is neither alignment nor uniformity.

05

Simplify before you digitalise

Following **Jeanne Ross of MIT CISR**, the book argues that most enterprises are not too small or too old to be digital — they are too complex. The remedy is an **operational backbone**: the shared core the enterprise runs on, surrounded by an **edge** where it competes on difference.



Standardise the backbone ruthlessly; differentiate the edge deliberately. Most enterprises do the reverse: a fragmented core drowning in variants.

Retire before you add

No new AI capability enters a workflow until its redundant variants are named and scheduled for removal.

The business decides what is standard

Simplification imposed by IT alone fails; the business knows which variants carry real customer value.

Redesign the workflow, not the model

McKinsey's State of AI research keeps finding that the companies capturing value redesign workflows rather than deploy the most models. The workflow is the unit of transformation, redesigned in four moves — always in this order.

1
Define the outcome
One sentence, with a number in it.

2
Allocate the work
Agent alone, agent prepares, or human only.

3
Design the boundaries
Authority limits, escalations, never-do rules, audit trail.

4
Rewire the measures
Or the old workflow quietly returns.

Every redesign brings a **performance dip**. It is announced in advance, bounded, measured weekly and exited on criteria. What kills programmes is not the dip but the surprise of it.

FOR THE COO

You own end-to-end workflow ownership and the dip. **Redesign one workflow at a time, manage the dip openly, and never ask the operation to pause.**

KEY TAKEAWAYS

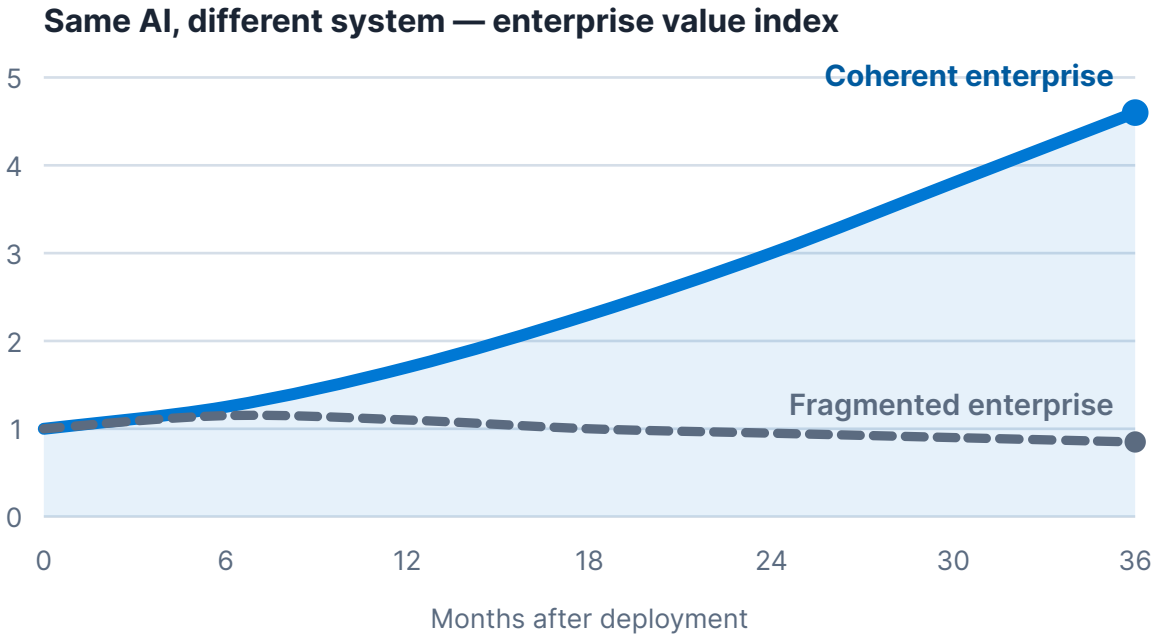
- ✔ The backbone/edge line decides where agents may act.
- ✔ Transformation happens per workflow, in four ordered moves.
- ✔ A planned dip is a managed variable; a surprise dip kills programmes.

06

AI amplifies the system it enters

AI brings no way of working of its own. It accelerates the one it finds.

> “ The technology is the amplifier; the enterprise is the signal.
>
> INTRODUCTION



Illustrative trajectory, as shown in the book. The technology is identical; only the system differs.

For decades incoherence was expensive but survivable, because competitors carried the same burden. AI ends that truce. Agentic AI raises the stakes from advice to action: an agent that places orders or moves money must know who owns the outcome, where its authority ends and what it may never do. That is why agentic initiatives stall between demo and production — the technology is ready, but the organisation has not yet decided what it is allowed to decide.

Autonomy is earned with evidence

Human in the loop is a design decision, not a slogan. Each workflow step sits in one of three positions. An agent starts supervised and graduates; **it never starts free.**

POSITION 1

Human commands, agent executes

Irreversible, high-value or regulated actions

POSITION 2

Agent executes, human supervises

Reversible, bounded actions on the backbone

POSITION 3

Agent acts autonomously

High-volume, low-risk micro-decisions on verified data

MORE HUMAN JUDGEMENT

MORE AGENT AUTONOMY →

Every agent needs what every process needs: an owner, a documented scope, guardrails and auditability. Agentic AI is **cognitive capital**, not cheaper labour — treat it as ten-percent-cheaper labour and you get ten-percent outcomes.

FOR THE CIO · THE FALSE NEGATIVE

A capable agent fails in a confused environment and the organisation concludes that "AI doesn't work here". **The verdict is wrong, and it costs years.** Build agent governance into the platform, not around it.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- ✔ The same AI compounds value or confusion, depending on the system.
- ✔ Agents force the enterprise to write down what it left implicit.
- ✔ Place the human deliberately; earn autonomy with evidence.

07

Five steps, five gates

The method is a rhythm, not a programme. Each step is timeboxed and closes with a gate held by a named executive. A gate can pass, adjust or stop — **never drift**.

1	**Mandate & diagnosis** Costs, heatmap, gap map, one selected workflow	**CEO** 15 working days
2	**Readiness & capability** A verdict per domain: proceed, fix in parallel, fix first	**CEO + CIO** 10 working days
3	**Direction** A North Star AI vision and a portfolio sequenced on impact and feasibility	**CEO** 10 working days
4	**Workflow activation** Four redesign moves, the dip managed, value measured by Finance	**COO** 6–12 weeks each
5	**Anchoring & scaling** Governance into the line; funding only at 1.5× verified value	**CFO** Continuous

FOR THE CEO

You carry the mandate: open the first gate, set the course, and protect the single priority list. **Coherence cannot be delegated to a transformation office** — the gates rotate across the executive team for that reason.

Diagnose first: fifteen working days

Five domains are scored against the three signals on a heatmap. Every cell needs an artefact: **a red without evidence is a grievance; an amber without evidence is a hope.** The reddest, costliest cell is where you start.

DOMAIN	WAITING DECISIONS	TRAVELLING WORK	COMPETING PRIORITIES
Business	RED	AMBER	AMBER
Data	AMBER	RED	GREEN
Technology	GREEN	RED	AMBER
Governance	RED	AMBER	RED
People	AMBER	GREEN	RED

Illustrative scoring. Your heatmap comes from your own artefacts: decision logs, workflow walks, data lineage, allocation maps.

A companion **gap map** makes three recurring gaps undeniable: the *ownership gap*, the *boundary gap* and the *capacity gap*.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- ✔ Five gates, each with a named owner and the right to stop.
- ✔ No workflow enters activation without a baseline and North Star link.
- ✔ Evidence, not opinion, decides where the transformation starts.

CHAPTER 08 · CASE STUDIES

Same model, different system

08

An industrial company introduced AI demand forecasting. The forecast improved within weeks — and the business did not move. The book presents it as a composite of several organisations.

BEFORE · MONTH 0–6

AI forecast
Improves within weeks

Procurement
Keeps its own safety logic

Production
Plans on last year's pattern

Sales
Promises dates from a private spreadsheet

No owner for the chain, no shared data, no agent boundaries.

AFTER · ONE WORKFLOW REDESIGNED

AI forecast
The model is unchanged

Forecast → purchase order
One owner end to end

Shared data
One forecast every function uses

Explicit agent boundaries
What the model decides, what it recommends

Adoption up

Safety stock down

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- ✓ The AI did not fail; the condition it entered was not an operating condition.
- ✓ One workflow, one owner, shared data and boundaries changed the outcome.
- ✓ The investment appeared in the numbers only after the redesign.

CHAPTER 09 · KEY TAKEAWAYS

09

Value arrives in three horizons

The book promises a mechanism, not a number. Finance fills the model with its own figures; what the model fixes is the shape of value.

0–6 months Avoidance and speed: misinvestments stopped, licences consolidated



1.0

6–18 months Verified workflow results: cycle times 30–40% shorter



2.3

18–36 months Compounding: each next workflow costs less



4.0+

Cumulative verified value index (illustrative, net of the performance dip).

Every claim must name its ledger line — **cost avoided, cost reduced, revenue enabled or risk reduced**. A claim that cannot name its type is not yet a claim.

FRAMEWORK · FIVE MEASUREMENT RULES

1. **Baseline first** — no value without a baseline measured before redesign.
2. **Finance verifies** — the project proposes, Finance disposes.
3. **Net of the dip** — dip costs are charged to the initiative that caused them.
4. **Creation to curation** — value is re-verified every quarter.
5. **The 1.5× rule** — structural funding only at 1.5× verified annual value.

CHAPTER 09 · KEY TAKEAWAYS

How this fails — and the counter-move

Transformations rarely fail on technology. They fail on seven governance signals, each visible to someone long before it reaches the board.

SIGNAL	COUNTER-MOVE
Hidden veto	Transfer decision rights in writing; make starved cases visible
Mispriced value	Price the case before it starts
Stalled champion	Train a second team; document the roles
Skipped training	No one signs a judgement untrained
Automation theatre	Redeploy freed hours; retire the old checks
Gravity	Re-run the heatmap on a fixed cadence
False negative	No agent enters a process whose heatmap is red

CRITICAL RECOMMENDATION · THE HIDDEN TAX

Integration, monitoring and unowned agents often cost more than the licence itself. **Coherence is the exemption.**

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- ✔ Value compounds: 1.0 in six months, 2.3 by eighteen, 4.0 and rising by thirty-six.
- ✔ Five rules turn funding from advocacy into arithmetic.
- ✔ Every failure signal is a governance failure, not a technology one.

10

The first fifteen working days

Day 1–2 — **Open the gate**
The CEO names one value stream and opens the gate in writing — "do nothing here" is an acceptable outcome. CEO

Day 3–9 — **Diagnose and price**
Diagnostic, heatmap and a priced shortlist of fixes and pilots. Diagnostic Lead, Value Analyst

Day 10–12 — **Rehearse**
With the COO, CIO, CFO and employee representatives; a three-page board package. Executive team

Day 13 — **Decide**
Open Gate 1, or close with reasons minuted. Never "further study". Board

Day 14–15 — **Close the loop**
Report back to everyone interviewed; schedule the heatmap re-run. CEO

Each week of postponement is not caution; it is the cost of incoherence, still accruing at three to eight percent of revenue. Day fifteen does not deliver a transformation. It delivers an honest picture of your coherence, priced choices and a decision actually taken.

> **“The question the book leaves you with: which Monday?**
>
> CHAPTER 12

Design for coherence. Then amplify.

Diagnose first. Fix the workflow before the technology touches it. Price the case before you build it.

IN THE FULL BOOK

Twelve chapters and three appendices take each idea further: the contribution and the gate each executive role signs; the capability curriculum of progressive exposure; the twenty-one conversations that move culture; a reflection for the executive team at the close of every chapter; and reference appendices with the nine delivery roles, a glossary and the instruments at a glance.

About the author

Erlend Hollebosch works on enterprise coherence and AI transformation, with a background in Agile, Lean and process optimisation.

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KEY TAKEAWAYS

- ✔ Fifteen working days produce a decision, not a programme.
- ✔ Start where the evidence is reddest and the cost is highest.
- ✔ The only remaining question is when you begin.

Design for coherence. Then amplify.

Turning AI Potential into Enterprise Value — an executive preview of the short book for the executive team.

Back to the start

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